

and coffee and snacks, so those prospering in the bankrupt capitalist system can keep bathing in calves' blood or whatever it is they do.

I'm not alone. One of these budget hounds' biggest critics is the author Helaine Olen, whose book *Pound Foolish* is subtitled *Exposing the Dark Side of the Personal Finance Industry*. I originally found Olen while looking up videos of Suze Orman, and Olen's criticism of Orman hit on a creeping doubt I'd been feeling in my heart.

Olen posits that condescending, overconfident experts like Orman and Ramsey are part of the machine that broke us, and now they make money selling the repair schematics back to us. They get richer and richer doling out conflicting bits of advice disguised as gospel, she said, and we pay for the pleasure of being told to cut back on coffee.

Being prudent with your money is all well and good, but what about the system we're living under that benefits only a select few? Budgeting implies the poorest of the poor have to spend less, so the richest of the rich can spend more (as I said, on all that calves' blood keeping them looking young).

Olen said in a 2013 *CBS News* interview, "All we want is someone to tell us what to do." It's very easy to fall under the spell of one of these gurus if you're floundering because you're exhausted and sad and someone is claiming to have a solution. Honestly, I get it. The number of times I've driven past a Scientology billboard during a deep depression and felt like, "Fuck it," is too high for me to judge anyone who worships Suze Orman or Dave Ramsey.

The commenters on the CBS video of Helaine Olen are split: some say she's promoting a victim mentality and others say that she is making money shitting on successful gurus out of jealousy or contrarianism. Others agree that the "shame and blame" inherent in not looking at the rising cost of insurance and medical bills and the disgusting stagnation of wages for the average person doesn't take into account the whole picture. I agree with Olen because I'm a *Mad Max: Fury Road* burn-it-all-down anarchist at my core. But I'm still trying to game this system I know is ugly. Olen thinks by encouraging people to give up their lattes rather than rioting at expensive health care, we're plugging a massive leak with a wine cork. "If you just learn this stuff, then we don't need the